

We've Remodeled Homes for 22 Years. Here Are 22 Things We Wish Every Homeowner Knew Before Renovating

After 22 years in the remodeling industry, you learn that the most expensive mistakes often happen before anyone picks up a hammer.

Homeowners naturally spend a lot of time thinking about what a finished renovation will look like: the kitchen they've always wanted, a larger primary suite, an additional living space or finally transforming the house they've lived in for years.

But the decisions that determine whether a remodel becomes a great investment—or a frustrating and expensive experience—often happen much earlier.

As VL Pro Construction marks 22 years in remodeling, we wanted to share some of the lessons we've learned along the way.

Not design trends. Not a sales pitch.

Just 22 things we believe homeowners should know before spending serious money on their homes.

1. The cheapest bid isn't necessarily the cheapest project.

A lower number doesn't mean much unless you're comparing the same scope of work.

One contractor may include permits, demolition, project management, preparation, cleanup and certain materials while another leaves some of those items out.

Don't just compare the number at the bottom.

Compare what you're actually buying.

2. A detailed scope of work can be more important than the contract price.

"Remodel kitchen" leaves a lot open to interpretation.

What is being demolished? What stays? Who supplies the fixtures? What level of finish is included? What happens to the flooring? Who handles electrical or plumbing changes?

Ambiguity before construction often becomes disagreement during construction.

Get specific.

3. Your budget shouldn't equal your maximum available cash.

Renovations can uncover things nobody could reasonably see before demolition.

Water damage. Old wiring. Plumbing problems. Structural conditions. Previous work that wasn't completed correctly.

Leave room in your finances for the unexpected.

4. Changing your mind gets more expensive after construction begins.

Moving an outlet on a drawing is easy.

Moving it after drywall is installed isn't.

The more decisions you make before construction starts, the fewer expensive decisions you're likely to make during construction.

5. Spend money where you live, not where Instagram tells you to.

Trends are useful inspiration, but your home needs to work for your family.

Think about where you spend your time, what frustrates you about the current house and what would genuinely improve everyday life.

Great remodeling solves problems before it creates photographs.

6. Bigger isn't always better.

Sometimes the solution isn't another 1,000 square feet.

A better layout can make an existing home feel dramatically different without adding unnecessary space.

Before deciding to expand, ask whether the existing footprint is being used effectively.

7. Ask about permits before asking about countertops.

The exciting decisions get attention.

But permitting, engineering, zoning and structural requirements can have a much larger impact on your project's feasibility, budget and schedule.

Understand the constraints first.

8. Allowances deserve your attention.

If a proposal contains allowances for materials or fixtures, understand what those numbers actually buy.

An unrealistic allowance can make an initial proposal appear attractive and then push the final project cost higher as selections are made.

9. Don't choose a contractor from photographs alone.

Beautiful finished-project photos are valuable, but they don't tell you everything about what happened between demolition and completion.

Look at reputation, communication, documentation, experience, licensing where applicable and how the company handles problems.

10. Ask what isn't included.

One of the most useful questions you can ask during the bidding process is surprisingly simple:

"What am I going to need that isn't included in this price?"

The answer can reveal a lot.

11. Your contractor should be willing to tell you when an idea doesn't make sense.

You aren't only paying someone to build.

You're paying for experience.

Sometimes the most valuable advice a contractor can give you is that something isn't worth doing.

12. Think about the entire house.

A beautiful new kitchen can make the adjoining 20-year-old flooring suddenly feel very old.

Renovations interact with the spaces around them.

Think about transitions, sight lines and how the new space will connect to the existing home.

13. Don't wait until construction to make every selection.

Fixtures, appliances, tile and other products can affect dimensions, installation requirements and scheduling.

Late selections can create late changes.

14. Understand who is actually managing your project.

Ask who your point of contact will be once construction begins.

Know who makes decisions, who communicates schedule changes and who you call when you have a question.

15. Communication problems become construction problems.

Many remodeling frustrations aren't caused by someone's inability to build.

They're caused by mismatched expectations.

Discuss communication frequency, change orders, working hours, access to the home and how decisions will be documented before construction starts.

16. Your house may tell you things nobody knew before demolition.

Existing homes contain surprises.

Good planning reduces uncertainty, but remodeling will never be identical to manufacturing something in a controlled factory.

Plan accordingly.

17. Don't evaluate every upgrade solely by resale value.

Return on investment matters, especially if you expect to sell soon.

But your home is also where you live.

A renovation that dramatically improves your family's life for the next decade can have value that doesn't appear on a resale spreadsheet.

18. But don't ignore the neighborhood either.

There is a point where additional investment may not translate proportionally into additional property value.

Consider the home, neighborhood, expected length of ownership and your financial objectives together.

19. Ask how changes are priced before you make one.

Change orders happen.

The important thing is understanding the process.

Know how changes will be documented, approved and priced before construction begins.

20. The best time to solve a problem is before construction.

Planning may not feel productive because nothing is physically changing yet.

But drawings, selections, scope discussions and careful decisions can save enormous amounts of time later.

Don't rush planning just because you're excited to start building.

21. Build for the way you actually live.

Where do groceries land when you enter the house?

Where do the kids drop their backpacks?

Where do people congregate when guests come over?

Where do you charge your phone?

Those mundane questions can matter more to everyday satisfaction than many expensive design features.

22. A successful remodel isn't just a beautiful finished room.

It's a project where expectations, budget, design and construction ultimately came together.

Twenty-two years in remodeling has taught us that craftsmanship matters tremendously—but preparation matters too.

The homeowners who enter a renovation informed, realistic and prepared tend to make better decisions throughout the process.

That's ultimately why we're sharing these lessons as we celebrate our 22nd year.

If you're considering a renovation, don't begin by asking what countertops are popular or what color cabinets everyone is installing.

Begin with the bigger questions.

What problem are you trying to solve?

How long will you live in the house?

What's your real budget?

And what needs to go right for you to consider the renovation a success?

Answer those questions first.

Everything else becomes easier from there.